

ROUTE & SESSION PACING

1. Pine Foothills

Evergreens, creek, broken trails. Find Skritch: shelter, cloak, rations, kobold blood. Best for tracks, ambush, and retrieval team.

2. Stone Stairs

Switchbacks, ledges, Erie markers. Delegation becomes visible: smoke, patrols, excess gear, outriders, secret meetings.

3. Wind Pass

Open ridge, snow, changing visibility, huge drops. Players can mislead scouts, redirect traffic, damage bridges, or make rockslides.

4. Frostvein Heights

Ice cliffs, prayer poles, carved markers, hearth smoke. Destination becomes visible. End shortly after the reveal.

ENCOUNTER CHOOSER

- Follow Skritch -> retrieval team.
- Shadow delegation and get seen -> patrol.
- Make noise or enter nesting shelf -> Grimbeak.
- After one medium/hard fight, make later opposition a chase, rescue, stealth crossing, or negotiation.

CLOSING IMAGE

Snow clears. Frostvein's stone halls lie below, smoke rising from dozens of chimneys. Prayer poles clatter. Black Fang banners move on the lower road. Quickfeather circles overhead.

Cut to black: 'An Yue has agreed to hear both sides.'

GM question before any roll: *What are you trying to change?*

PEOPLE, CLUES & LEVERAGE

WHO KNOWS WHAT

Skritch: Half-frozen, starved, abandoned. Wants safety and revenge. Knows retrieval orders name Vekka.

Envoy Gorak: Public leader. Wants an honorable hearing. Does not know the deeper operation.

Quartermaster Vekka: Runs outriders and concealed reports. Protects the hidden objective and her deniability.

Veteran patrol leader: Believes the mission is peaceful. Ordered to capture interferers alive.

Rock Scale survivors: Serve Razor because he made kobolds feel important, not because they think themselves evil.

CLUE LADDER

- More rescue gear than diplomats need.
- Outriders make unusually wide loops.
- Two riders report to Vekka, not Gorak.
- Torn Black Fang cloak at Skritch's shelter.
- Orders: recover witness, burn route notes, report to Vekka.
- Kobolds know a hidden objective exists, not its whole purpose.

WHAT COUNTS AS LEVERAGE

- A living witness plus written orders.
- Evidence of reporting outside Gorak's command.
- Patrol testimony that rescue supplies were prepacked.
- A cooperative act proving the party protected Black Fang lives.

DO NOT OVERPROVE

No single clue establishes that Gorak or every guard is complicit. Let the players decide whether to expose Vekka, warn Gorak, approach Frostvein, or keep watching.

SESSION 08

SHADOWING THE PEACE BANNER

*Follow the diplomats.
Discover the truth.
Gain leverage before Frostvein.*

TABLE SNAPSHOT

3 hours | 5 level-3 heroes
Expected: 0-2 combats
Destination: Frostvein Heights

WHAT IS TRUE

The Black Fang travel beneath a real peace banner. Most guards believe this is diplomacy. Skritch knows the mission has hidden objectives, but not the full plan. Quartermaster Vekka receives reports outside Envoy Gorak's chain of command.

GM PRIORITIES

- Diplomacy over assumed hostility.
- Understanding over a single correct answer.
- Visible terrain toys before dice rolls.
- A fight avoided is a successful scene.

1 RECOVER SKRITCH

Easy skirmish | Goal: Recover Skritch, seize orders, escape. They do not fight to the death.

ROLE	QTY	STAT BLOCK
Rock Scale retriever	5	Kobold Sneak L1/2
Alchemist	1	Kobold Trapper L1
Rigger	1	Kobold Clanger L1
TOTAL		4.5 levels - intentionally easy

Retriever

- HP 15 | No Armor | Speed 6
- Stab/Sling: 1d4+2; Range 8.
 - Revenge: when ally dies, move 6 before Nooooo!
 - Nooooo!: ally dies within 2 -> free attack.

Alchemist

- HP 26 | No Armor | Speed 6
- Throw Scorpion (2x): Range 8, 1d4+2.
 - BEEES! (1/enc): trigger adjacent move; 5d4 cannot miss; half to all adjacent.
 - Hidden Net (1/enc): trigger adjacent move; Restrained, escape DC 10.

Rigger

- HP 16 | Heavy Armor | Speed 6
- CLANG!: allies who hear it roll 1 extra attack die.
 - Moves for orders; flees once secured.

BROKEN CREEK CAMP

- Shelter: half cover; orders inside.
- Creek: difficult terrain; shoved in -> Prone + bank cover.
- Pines: full cover across trunks.
- Snare: DC 10 DEX or Prone.
- North edge: escape with carried evidence/Skritch.

RUN THEM

- Rigger grabs orders, then runs.
- Alchemist nets the hero nearest Skritch.
- Retrievers screen, grapple, shove, and carry.
- Scatter when 2 leaders/3 retrievers fall, evidence is lost, or safe retreat is offered.

EVIDENCE

'Recover the witness. Burn the route notes. Report to Quartermaster Vekka - not the envoy.'

2 BLACK FANG PATROL

Main fight | Goal: Capture, question, release after safe passage. They believe this is diplomacy.

ROLE	QTY	STAT BLOCK
Veteran	1	Bandit Captain L4
Scout	3	Bandit Hunter L1
War warg	2	Worg L1
Fresh-party add	1	Bandit Bruiser L2
TOTAL		9 base / 11 with Bruiser

Veteran

- HP 36 | Medium Armor | Speed 6
- Slice (3x): 1d8+1; or Shoot, Range 8.
 - Spreads attacks; does not execute Dying heroes.

Scout

- HP 22 | No Armor | Speed 6
- Battlebow: Range 12, 2d8+2.
 - Targets ropes, exits, and threats to veteran.

War Warg

- HP 28 | No Armor | Speed 10
- Rip Apart (2x): 1d6+2; hit -> Grappled, escape DC 10.
 - Savage: always crits a Grappled target.

Shield-Bearer (optional)

- HP 24 | Medium Armor | Speed 6
- Bash: 2d8+4.
 - Use only if heroes are fresh; blocks stairs.

STONE STAIRS

- 3 elevations; each tier 20 ft -> 2d6 fall + Prone.
- Erie marker: cover. Upper shelf: Hunters.
- Rope bridge: cut, loosen, swing, or pull sideways.
- Peace pennant makes aggression politically visible.

CAPTURE REQUIRES ALL 3

- Target Grappled/Restrained/unconscious/surrendered.
- Patrol member spends 1 action binding.
- Patrol removes target or holds the field.

STOP FIGHTING IF

Credible internal-operation evidence; Bloodied veteran gets a face-saving truce; predator threatens both; or both sides protect the pennant.

Opening: 'Weapons down. You will be bound, questioned, and released when our passage is secure.'

3 GRIMBEAK, UNYIELDING

Optional hard set piece | Level 3 solo legendary. Territorial, not evil. Use only if the session needs a climax.

Grimbeak

- Large Owlbear | HP 100 | Medium Armor | STR+
- Brutal: highest die is Primary; crit -> Prone.
 - Acts after EACH hero turn - choose one action.
 - Savage Screech (1 use): all enemies Reach 12 take 2d6 ignoring Armor; DC 11 WIL or Frightened 1 round.
 - Rend & Tear: 2d6+10.
 - Beak: Move 8, then attack 2d6.
 - Bloodied 50 HP: Screech recharges.
 - Last Stand: at 0, needs 30 more damage; attacks use d10s instead of d6s.

WHY SHE ATTACKS

- Outrider stole an egg.
- Rockslide trapped her cub.
- Smoke/bells drove prey into nest.
- Bad markers led both groups through territory.

WIND PASS TOYS

- 4-space ridge; snow banks = difficult + half cover.
- 3 prayer poles can fall into 4-space barriers.
- Nest shelf contains egg/cub.
- End round: exposed edge DC 10 STR/DEX or move 2; first fall leaves creature hanging.
- Supply sled: rope, blankets, meat; distraction/anchor/projectile.

BLACK FANG SUPPORT - INIT 10

- Pull one hanging creature to safety.
- Move the supply sled 6 spaces.
- Give one hero advantage vs wind.
- Distract next Beak toward a guard.
- Secure/free egg or cub after route opens.

END WITHOUT KILLING

Egg/cub safe and nest clear; intruders retreat; Bloodied Grimbeak offered food and escape; or animal knowledge identifies the real threat.

WHAT COOPERATION REVEALS

Veteran protects lives, not cargo. One outrider retrieves Vekka's satchel. Rescue gear is perfectly organized for mountain casualties.

GLOBAL SAFETY VALVE

After one medium/hard fight, convert later opposition into a chase, negotiation, rescue, stealth crossing, or enemies fleeing when their objective is lost.